Getting Started — A Step-by-Step Setup Guide

For people who've never done this before — no tech experience needed.

Welcome! This guide walks you through getting the Finance Dashboard running on your computer for the very first time. Follow the steps in order and you'll be up and running in about 15 minutes.

What you'll need

- A **Mac or Windows PC**
- An **internet connection** (just for the initial setup — the app itself works offline after that)
- About **15 minutes** of your time

Part 1 — Install Node.js (the engine the app runs on)

The dashboard isn't a regular app you download from an app store. It's a web app that runs locally, and it needs a small program called **Node.js** to power it. Think of Node.js as the engine under the hood — you install it once and forget about it.

On a Mac

1. Go to nodejs.org in your browser.
2. Click the big green button that says **"LTS"** (not "Current") — LTS means it's the stable, recommended version.
3. Open the downloaded file (it'll be something like `node-v20.x.x.pkg`) and follow the installer. Just click **Continue → Continue → Install** and enter your Mac password when asked.

On Windows

1. Go to nodejs.org in your browser.
2. Click the **"LTS"** download button.
3. Open the `.msi` installer file and click through the wizard. Leave all the options at their defaults and click **Next → Next → Install**.

Check that it worked

Mac: Open the **Terminal** app (search for "Terminal" with Spotlight — press ⌘ Space and type "Terminal") and type this, then press Enter:

```
node --version
```

Windows: Open **Command Prompt** (press the Windows key, type "cmd", press Enter) and type the same thing.

If you see something like `v20.11.0` printed back, you're good. If you see an error, try restarting your computer and running it again.

Part 2 — Get the app on your computer

You need to download the app's files. There are three ways — pick the one that sounds least scary.

A quick note: GitHub and Git

GitHub is a website where code projects are stored and shared — think of it like Google Drive, but for code. The app lives there.

Git is the underlying tool that actually downloads ("clones") code from GitHub onto your computer. It's a small program, similar to Node.js, that runs quietly in the background.

- **Option A (GitHub Desktop)** installs Git for you automatically — you don't need to do anything extra.
- **Option B (Terminal)** requires Git to already be on your computer. If you haven't installed GitHub Desktop, you'll need to install Git separately first (instructions below).
- **Option C (zip download)** doesn't need Git at all.

Option A: GitHub Desktop (easier — recommended for staying up to date)

GitHub Desktop is a simple app for downloading and updating code projects without touching the terminal. It includes Git automatically — no separate install needed.

1. Go to desktop.github.com and click **Download for Mac** (or Windows). Install it like any normal app.
2. Open GitHub Desktop and sign in with a GitHub account. (If you don't have one, click **Create your free account** — it's free and takes two minutes.)
3. In the top menu, click **File → Clone Repository**.
4. Click the **URL** tab.
5. Paste in the address of the project (whoever shared this guide with you can give you the URL — it looks like `https://github.com/oc21-byte/finance-dashboard`).
6. Under **Local Path**, click **Choose...** and select your **Desktop**. This way the app folder will be easy to find.
7. Click **Clone**.

The app will download. You'll see a `finance-dashboard` folder appear on your Desktop. That folder is your app.

> ***Want to move it later?*** *If the folder ends up somewhere you don't like, you can move it the same way you'd move any folder — drag and drop it wherever you want in Finder (Mac) or File Explorer (Windows). Just remember the new location for future steps.*

Option B: Terminal / command line

This option uses the `git` command directly in your terminal. Before you can run it, **Git must be installed on your computer**.

Install Git first (if you haven't already)

On a Mac:

1. Open **Terminal** (press ⌘ Space, type "Terminal", press Enter).
2. Type `git --version` and press Enter.
3. If Git is already installed, you'll see a version number — skip to the clone step below. If not, macOS will automatically pop up a window and ask if you'd like to install **Xcode Command Line Tools** — click **Install** and wait a few minutes. Git is included.

On Windows:

1. Go to git-scm.com/download/win — the download will start automatically.
2. Open the installer and click through the wizard. **Leave all the options at their defaults** and click **Next → Next → Install**. The defaults are fine.

3. Once installed, open a new Command Prompt and type `git --version` to confirm it worked.

Clone the project onto your Desktop

Once Git is installed, open Terminal (Mac) or Command Prompt (Windows) and run these commands one at a time, pressing Enter after each:

On a Mac:

```
cd ~/Desktop
git clone https://github.com/oc21-byte/finance-dashboard.git
cd finance-dashboard
```

On Windows:

```
cd %USERPROFILE%\Desktop
git clone https://github.com/oc21-byte/finance-dashboard.git
cd finance-dashboard
```

The first command navigates to your Desktop. The second downloads the project there, creating a `finance-dashboard` folder. The third steps into that folder so you're ready for the next part.

Option C: Download as a zip (simplest — no updates)

If you just want to try the app and don't care about getting future updates, you can download it as a plain zip file:

1. Go to the project page on GitHub (ask whoever shared this guide for the link).
2. Click the green **Code** button near the top right.
3. Click **Download ZIP**.
4. Open your Downloads folder, find the zip file, and double-click it to unzip it.
5. Move the resulting folder somewhere convenient (Desktop or Documents works fine).

> ***Note:*** *With this method, getting future updates means downloading a new zip and replacing the folder manually. If you think you'll want updates, Option A is easier in the long run.*

Part 3 — Install the app's pieces

The app comes with a list of small code libraries it needs. You install them all with one command. You only ever need to do this step once (and again after major updates).

Mac: Open **Terminal** and navigate to the app folder. The easiest way is to:

1. Open a new Terminal window.
2. Type `cd ` (with a space after it — don't press Enter yet).
3. Open Finder, find the folder you just cloned, and **drag the folder onto the Terminal window**. The path to the folder will appear automatically.
4. Now press **Enter**.

Windows: Open the folder in File Explorer, then click the address bar at the top, type `cmd`, and press Enter. A Command Prompt window will open already pointing to that folder.

Now type this and press Enter:

```
npm install
```

You'll see a lot of text scroll by — this is completely normal. It's just downloading small pieces of code the app needs. When it stops and you see a prompt (`$` on Mac, `>` on Windows), it's done.

Part 4 — Launch the app

Every time you want to use the app, you'll do this. Pick whichever option is easier for you.

Option A: Double-click to launch (easiest)

Inside the app folder there's a launcher file — double-click it and a terminal window will open, the app will start, and your browser will open automatically to `http://localhost:5173`.

- **Mac:** double-click **"(Mac) Launch Finance Dashboard.command"**
- **Windows:** double-click **"(Windows) Launch Finance Dashboard.bat"**

> ***Mac only — first time:*** *macOS may warn you that the file is from an unidentified developer. If you see that message, right-click (or Control-click) the file and choose* ***Open****, then click* ***Open*** *again in the dialog. You'll only need to do this once.*

> ***Important:*** *Keep the terminal window that opens while you're using the app — it's what's running everything.*

Option B: Terminal / Command Prompt

1. Open Terminal (Mac) or Command Prompt (Windows) inside the app folder (same way as Part 3).
2. Type this and press Enter:

```
npm run dev
```

3. You'll see some startup text. When you see something like:

```
  ➜  Local:   http://localhost:5173/
```

...the app is ready. Open your web browser and go to:

```
http://localhost:5173
```

That's it — the dashboard opens in your browser, just like any website.

> ***Important:*** *Keep the Terminal / Command Prompt window open while you're using the app — the window is what's running everything.*

Stopping the app

The cleanest way is to use the **Close App button** built into the dashboard itself:

1. In the top-right corner of the app (next to the Settings gear), click the **red stop icon** (■).
2. A small confirmation pop-up appears — click **Close App**.
3. The server shuts down, and the pop-up changes to show a **Close Tab** button. Click it to close your browser tab.

Alternatively, switch back to your Terminal / Command Prompt window and press **Ctrl + C**. Both methods work; the in-app button is just more convenient.

> ***VS Code users:*** *You can open an integrated terminal inside VS Code with* `Ctrl+`` *(backtick) and run* `npm run dev` *from there. The app stays running in that terminal panel. Use the Close App button as usual to stop it.*

Part 5 — Get an AI key (pick one)

The dashboard's smartest features — automatically reading PDF statements, writing plain-English insights about your spending, and building a personalized budget — use an AI service in the background. You connect it with an "API key," which is just a password-like code that identifies your account.

You only need **one** key. Pick whichever AI service you prefer.

Option A: Claude (Anthropic) — *recommended for PDF reading*

Claude is Anthropic's AI. It's the best option for reading messy PDF bank statements.

Step 1 — Create an account

1. Go to console.anthropic.com.
2. Click **Sign Up**, enter your email address, and verify it.
3. You'll land on the Anthropic Console dashboard.

Step 2 — Create an API key

1. In the left sidebar, click **API Keys**.
2. Click the **+ Create Key** button.
3. Give it a name (like "Finance Dashboard") and click **Create Key**.
4. A long code starting with `sk-ant-…` will appear. **Copy it now** — you won't be able to see it again after you close this window. Paste it somewhere temporary (like a Notes app) so you don't lose it.

Step 3 — Add credits Anthropic charges tiny amounts per use (typically a fraction of a cent for most features — see the cost breakdown in the User Guide). You need to add credits before it'll work:

1. In the left sidebar, click **Settings**, then **Billing**.
2. Click **Add credits**.
3. Enter $5 and a payment card. That $5 will last months of normal personal use.

Step 4 — Add the key to the dashboard

1. Open the dashboard in your browser (at `http://localhost:5173`).
2. Click **Settings** (the ⚙ gear icon, top-right).
3. Under **AI Provider**, make sure **Claude** is selected.
4. Find the **Claude API Key** field and paste your key.
5. Click **Save Key**.
6. You'll see a green **Configured** ✓ badge. Done!

Option B: ChatGPT (OpenAI)

OpenAI makes ChatGPT. If you already have an OpenAI account, this is the quickest option.

Step 1 — Create an account

1. Go to platform.openai.com.
2. Click **Sign Up** and follow the prompts to create an account.

Step 2 — Create an API key

1. Once logged in, click your profile icon (top-right) → **API Keys**, or go directly to platform.openai.com/api-keys.
2. Click **+ Create new secret key**.
3. Give it a name and click **Create secret key**.
4. A code starting with `sk-…` will appear. **Copy it immediately** — it won't be shown again.

Step 3 — Add credits

1. In the left sidebar, click **Billing**.
2. Click **Add to credit balance**.
3. Enter $5 and a payment card. That covers months of personal use.

Step 4 — Add the key to the dashboard

1. Open the dashboard at `http://localhost:5173`.
2. Click **Settings** (⚙ top-right).
3. Under **AI Provider**, select **ChatGPT**.
4. Paste your key into the **OpenAI API Key** field.
5. Click **Save Key**.
6. You'll see a green **Configured** ✓ badge. Done!

Part 6 — Your first few minutes

The app is running and your AI key is in. Here's what to do next:

1. **Set your monthly income** — go to Settings and enter your usual take-home pay under **Monthly Income Baseline**. This helps the Budget Builder make sensible suggestions later.

2. **Upload your first bank statement** — go to the **Finances** tab and click **Upload Bank Statement**. Download a CSV export from your online banking and drop it in. The app will walk you through a one-time setup for that account, then it'll be instant on every future upload. (See Step 2 of the User Guide for the full walkthrough.)

3. **Upload a credit card statement** — same idea, but on the **Spend Analyzer** tab.

4. **Check the Dashboard** — once you have some transactions in, the Dashboard will start showing your liquid net worth trend, where the change came from, and (if you set up an AI key) some written insights about your spending.

5. **Set some goals** — head to the **Goals** tab and try the Emergency Fund Calculator at the top. It uses your real spending to suggest a target automatically.

That's it — you're set up. Come back to the User Guide any time you want to dig deeper into a specific feature.

Troubleshooting

"Port 5173 is already in use" Another copy of the app is already running in a different terminal window. Find that window and close it (or press Ctrl + C inside it), then run `npm run dev` again. If you can't find it,

on a Mac run `killall node` in Terminal (on Windows, `taskkill /F /IM node.exe` in Command Prompt) — this stops every copy at once, and your data is safe.

"npm: command not found" (or "node is not recognized") Node.js didn't install correctly. Go back to Part 1, reinstall it, restart your computer, and try again.

"Error fetching stock prices" This is normal — the live stock price lookup occasionally fails. Refresh the page or wait a minute and try again. It doesn't affect any other features.

The app isn't saving my changes Make sure the Terminal window running `npm run dev` is still open. If you accidentally closed it, just run `npm run dev` again — your data is safe in `data/db.json` and will reload automatically.

Something looks wrong after an update If the app behaves strangely after pulling new code, run `npm install` again (in case new packages were added) and restart with `npm run dev`.

Red screen: `Failed to resolve import "…"` (e.g. `"xlsx"`) You pulled new code but didn't reinstall packages. A pull only downloads source files — new libraries stay missing until you install them. From the project folder, run `npm install`, then `npm run dev` again.

Still stuck? Reach out to whoever shared this app with you — they'll be able to help.